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Salt Lines: Chloride in Upper Midwest Lakes

Proposal for the 2027 Hollis Fellowship in Environmental Reporting

Owen Brandt | September 14, 2026

FORMAT	TERM	REPORTING BUDGET
Four-part reported series with a public data appendix	Feb. 1 to July 31, 2027, half-time	$6,800, separate from the stipend

THE STORY

Every winter, cities, counties and contractors across the Upper Midwest spread road salt by the ton. The sodium chloride that keeps roads passable washes into storm sewers, streams and lakes, and the chloride stays. It does not settle out. It does not break down. Once it reaches a lake, it leaves only with the water that flows out, and what soaks into the ground can come back in another season.

Minnesota's chronic standard for chloride, the level aquatic life can tolerate over time, is 230 milligrams per liter. Monitoring in the Twin Cities already puts several lakes near or above that line.

Road salt is not a scandal. It is a trade almost everyone makes: safer winter roads for saltier water the rest of the year. The people who pay for the second half of that trade are mostly not the people who spread the salt. Watershed districts, small local agencies most residents never think about, carry much of the cost of measuring the damage and trying to slow it.

Salt Lines will follow the chloride from the plow route to the lake to the aquifer, read the monitoring data closely, check selected numbers with independent samples, and ask who pays.

WHY NOW

The data have only lately become good enough to tell this story well. The Metro Lakes Watershed District's 2025 water-quality report, published in June, added a third phase of monitoring: a storm-sewer inlet, where snowmelt reaches a lake first, and a lake outlet, where the water leaves. For the first time there are inlet numbers to set beside the lake means.

The same report found that member cities used 9% more road salt in the 2024-25 winter than in 2023-24, a winter that was unusually mild. Sorting weather from habit is part of the job. Either way, cities are training crews to use less salt, and total use has not come down.

Last week North Current, the Minneapolis magazine I write for most often, approved my feature on road salt and Twin Cities lakes, to be filed in November. That piece can cover one district and one winter. The fellowship would carry the reporting across the region and through a full melt season, and give the data the time they need.

THE SERIES

Part 1. The salt we spread. How much salt cities, counties, the state and private applicators put down each winter, what it costs them, and what changes when crews are trained to use less. The district's survey

covers city streets only. Private applicators, who treat parking lots, driveways and sidewalks, keep few public records, and the estimates of their share that get passed around rarely come with a source. I will build the public side from purchase and application records and report the private side as what it is: an estimate, with its basis shown. The part ends with crews and property managers who have cut their salt use and kept their lots safe.

Part 2. What the lakes hold. A close reading of district monitoring data: which lakes are over the standard, which are close, how the samples were collected and analyzed, and what the new inlet and outlet stations add. Agencies revise their reports, and annual means can hide spikes, so every figure will be traced to the document, table, page and edition it came from. I will check selected sites with independent samples and report plainly where my numbers agree with the district's and where they do not.

Part 3. The bill. What watershed districts spend on chloride monitoring and prevention, where the money comes from and what it buys. There is no practical way to pull chloride back out of a lake, so the spending goes to measuring the problem and keeping more salt out. I will read district budgets line by line, compare costs per lake across districts, and ask the people who write those budgets what more money, or less, would change. The Metro Lakes board is working through its 2027 budget this fall, which gives me a first set of numbers to build from.

Part 4. Under the lakes. Chloride that soaks into the ground does not stay there. It moves through shallow groundwater and seeps back into streams and lakes, sometimes years later, so a city that cut its salt use tomorrow might wait a long time to see its lakes respond. I will report what researchers in Duluth and Madison are learning about how much chloride is stored underground and how long it takes to come back out. I will also travel to northern Wisconsin lake country, where some watersheds have few roads, for a sense of what the baseline looks like.

METHOD

- **Primary sources only.** Agency reports, budget documents, original monitoring data, lab reports and recorded interviews. A claim from social media, a blog or another outlet is traced to an original source before it is used, or it is left out.
- **Every figure tracked.** Each number goes into a claims tracker with its source, page and date, so an editor or fact-checker can audit the series line by line.
- **Independent samples.** About 40 over the term, collected in lab-supplied bottles, kept on ice and logged on chain-of-custody forms, then analyzed by a commercial laboratory. Each result will be reported with the lab's method and the date and place it was collected.
- **Open data.** The data behind the series, with sources and notes, will be published in a public appendix. If a number changes after publication, the appendix will show the change and the date.

PUBLICATION

I will offer the series to the regional nonprofit and magazine outlets I write for regularly. The data appendix will be free for any newsroom to republish, with credit.

TIMELINE

2027	Work
February to March	Records requests to districts, counties and cities. Compile monitoring and budget data. Snowmelt sampling at storm-sewer inlets.
April to May	Field reporting and interviews in the Twin Cities, Duluth, Madison and northern Wisconsin. Spring samples at lake sites.
June	Writing, data checks and fact-checking. Build the data appendix.
July	Publication of Parts 1 to 4 and the data appendix.

REPORTING BUDGET

Item	Basis	Amount
Independent lab analysis	About 40 samples at roughly $90 each	$3,600
Travel	Duluth, Madison and northern Wisconsin: mileage, lodging and meals	$2,900
Records requests and data fees	Copying and data-extract charges	$300
Total reporting budget		**$6,800**

The reporting budget is separate from the stipend and matches the itemized request in the application.

ABOUT THE REPORTER

Owen Brandt has reported in Minnesota for 27 years: 20 at the Twin Cities Ledger, from 1999 to 2019, and since July 2019 as a freelance science and environment journalist. He writes for North Current, Great Lakes Dispatch, Prairie Wire and Field & Flow, and checks one viral claim a month for North Current's fact-check column. His submitted clips are "Ice-out on the Big Lake" and "Who pays for beach closures" (Great Lakes Dispatch, 2026) and "Brine before the storm" (Twin Cities Ledger, 2018). He is a member of the Society of Environmental Journalists and lives in Minneapolis.